

A BAGFUL OF HAZARD

Despite a government ban in 2003, Uttar Pradesh learns no lessons and continues to drown in its plastic waste

Photographs by MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

CRIMINAL WASTE: Plastic piles up on the bank of Gomati



■ **By Subhash Mishra**

It is an innocuous practice in offices in Uttar Pradesh to order tea from the nearest roadside dhaba. What is not so innocuous is how the tea is carried to these offices—in plastic bags. Neither the dhaba owners nor those relishing the beverage have any time to think of the hazardous consequences of their seemingly harmless tea breaks.

In fact, not just hazardous. What

they do is also illegal. Hot tea, carried in thin-grade plastic pouches, not only exposes them to the noxious effects of plastic but also violates a law. The Uttar Pradesh Government had banned the use of polyethylene bags with an amendment in the Environment Protection Act in 2003. Polyethylene bags with thickness of less than 20 micron and a size of less than 20x30 cm have been banned under the directive of the Central Government. The bags must also be

colourless as coloured bags are usually made from recycled material, and should not be used to carry eatables.

Despite the ban, in state capital Lucknow itself, there are still nearly 2,000 manufacturing units of plastic products and 125 tonne of plastic bags are supplied to the city every year. These ubiquitous bags—90 per cent of which flout government norms on thickness and colour—are everywhere, right from a small grocery shop to big malls. Compared to five years ago, the production and usage of these bags have gone up by several degrees.

There is rarely an urban landscape in the state where the bags cannot be sighted. They choke drains, canals and water reservoirs besides contaminating water and, when burnt in waste, lead to air pollution. The worst affected are domestic cattle as they consume the food waste, most often wrapped in plastic, that is thrown away by people. The state veterinary department, over a period of five years, has saved over 3,000 cows from dying due to choking on plastic bags. Not only livestock, zoo animals also fall victim to this. Renu Singh, director of Lucknow Zoo, says visitors often throw eatables wrapped in plastic bags into the enclosures having animals. "It's a serious threat to their lives," Singh says.

The havoc caused by the bags extends into the countryside. Plastic bags contaminate rivers, forests and agricultural fields. The aquatic life of the river Gomati is deteriorating because of the plastic bags flowing from sewer lines. They often choke the sewage system but when it is cleared and cleaned, all the bags enter its water directly. From time to time, thousands of dead fish are seen floating on the river.

The Government has asked the municipal corporations, district administrations and the Uttar Pradesh Pollution Control Board (UPPCB) to carry out awareness campaigns. People everywhere use these bags because they are light and easy to carry and save stuff from water. The government campaigns seek to make them understand that it is environmentally saner to carry grocery in cloth or paper bags.

Strangely, Lucknow Mayor Dinesh Sharma is ignorant of his own municipal corporation's power to ban these bags. He is quick to promise action on